

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

HOUSE JOINT MEMORIAL NO. 14

BY RESOURCES AND CONSERVATION COMMITTEE

A JOINT MEMORIAL

TO THE PRESIDENT OF THE UNITED STATES, TO THE SECRETARY OF THE INTERIOR, TO
THE COMMISSIONER OF THE BUREAU OF RECLAMATION, TO THE SENATE AND THE
HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE UNITED STATES IN CONGRESS ASSEMBLED,
AND TO THE CONGRESSIONAL DELEGATION REPRESENTING THE STATE OF IDAHO IN
THE CONGRESS OF THE UNITED STATES.

We, your Memorialists, the House of Representatives and the Senate of the State of Idaho assembled in the Second Regular Session of the Sixty-eighth Idaho Legislature, do hereby respectfully represent that:

WHEREAS, water is the foundation of Idaho's farms, communities, and economy, yet the Eastern Snake Plain Aquifer continues to decline, forcing water curtailments that now threaten farmers and ground water users every year; and

WHEREAS, Idaho faces longer, hotter summers and warmer winters that reduce snowpack and cause runoff to occur earlier in the year, leaving less water available when it is needed most; and

WHEREAS, the State of Idaho irrigates more acres than ever before, but shrinking and inconsistent snowpack has created shortages that harm farms, cities, fish, and industry; and

WHEREAS, Idaho loses between 1.5 and 2 million acre-feet of water each year as it flows down the Snake River and out to the ocean simply because the state lacks sufficient reservoir space to capture it; and

WHEREAS, while aquifer recharge has proven to be an effective tool, it cannot be sustained without additional late-season water derived from storage; and

WHEREAS, the Idaho Legislature has demonstrated its commitment to water infrastructure through significant annual appropriations, and the people of Idaho have demonstrated broad public support for the research and construction of new reservoirs and expanded storage capacity; and

WHEREAS, to secure the future of our farms, communities, and economy, Idaho must commit to a long-term vision to build 750,000 acre-feet of new water storage by the year 2100; and

WHEREAS, practical near-term solutions have been identified, including modest raises at Minidoka Dam, Jackson Lake, and American Falls Dam; and

WHEREAS, mid-range and long-term opportunities exist for new reservoirs at locations such as Lane Lake, Chester, Soda Springs, Upper Badger Creek, Spring Creek, Moody Creek, and other potential sites, which would offer hydropower, extended irrigation seasons, flood protection, and recreation.

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED by the members of the Second Regular Session of the Sixty-eighth Idaho Legislature, the House of Representatives and the Senate concurring therein, that the Legislature respectfully urges the

1 United States Congress, the Department of the Interior, and the Bureau of
2 Reclamation to cooperate with the State of Idaho to:

3 (1) Move forward immediately with fast-track research on the feasi-
4 bility and desirability of small reservoir raises at Minidoka Dam, Jackson
5 Lake, and American Falls Dam;

6 (2) Support planning and design work for new medium-sized reservoirs
7 across eastern Idaho;

8 (3) Facilitate creative financing options through federal funds and
9 public-private partnerships; and

10 (4) Assist in the completion of an updated basin study in the next two to
11 three years to identify priority projects.

12 BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the State of Idaho commits to the goal of
13 "750k by 2100" by creating 750,000 acre-feet of new water storage by the year
14 2100 to turn today's water shortage into tomorrow's water security.

15 BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the Chief Clerk of the House of Representa-
16 tives be, and she is hereby authorized and directed to forward a copy of this
17 Memorial to the President of the United States, to the Secretary of the Inte-
18 rior, to the Commissioner of the Bureau of Reclamation, to the President of
19 the Senate and the Speaker of the House of Representatives of Congress, and
20 to the congressional delegation representing the State of Idaho in the Con-
21 gress of the United States.